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Pat LaBarbera

Saxophonist Pat LaBarbera grew up in a musical family and went on to become a noteworthy soloist with the Buddy Rich Band, Elvin Jones, and as a leader of his own combo. He has also become a distinguished jazz educator in a number of Canadian universities.

Pat was interviewed via Zoom on January 5, 2021, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe for the Fillius Jazz Archive, and I'm very pleased to have Pat LaBarbera with me this afternoon. And we are in two different countries but we're doing the Zoom thing. Welcome, Pat.

PL: Thank you, Monk, thanks for having me.

MR: Yeah. I wanted to tell you that I have been, as a child mostly, through Mount Morris many times. We used to travel from Rochester down to the Southern Tier to visit relatives. And when I saw that, about where you're from and your brothers, and I wondered if the Mount Morris Shopper, which was the local newspaper, did they ever do a story on your family band?

PL: Yeah, there was quite a — actually the Mount Morris Enterprise was the paper before that. There was two papers. You had the Picket Line Post and the Mount Morris Enterprise had early, really early stuff on us in the 50s. What the Shopper would do is they'd put those little photo sequences in. Like they'd put a picture from the past newspapers that were in town and then a little comment on that. But yes they did one on all of us and my father in that paper you know.

MR: Were your mother and father both on the same page as far as, I don't know if I can say "raising musicians" but I'm guessing this was not a chore for you.

PL: Well no. I think my mother just went along with the program. She played piano and she was interested in music. My mother was a nurse. My father was the one that really got us going with it. And he started us off really and kind of grooming us as a family band, and then we would go out and play jobs with my father or with a kind of a composite of something that he had put together with the three of us. Then my mother got upset because she was left at home, so she started playing bass, learning how to play bass, and then we went out as a family band and worked as a family band.

MR: So you were playing gigs at an early age. Did they pay you?

PL: We used to get five dollars sometimes, which was pretty good in 1954, '55 you know. But the jobs were like you played 55 minutes on and 5 minutes off, basically, for

started working in ’54 I think, ’54 yeah. I was eight. I was eight years old. And my brother Joe was probably working when he was around six or seven, maybe six.

MR: What was the set list like at that time? You probably were playing Swing Era tunes but also maybe whatever was on the radio?

PL: Swing and pop music of the day, Glenn Miller stocks, a lot of them were stock arrangements, a lot of Italian tunes. If it was Italian weddings we had to play all of the traditional Italian mazurkas and polkas. And so he had a whole library of that Italian music. And then the pop music of the day you know, which was in the 50s, and a lot of the stuff was — you had some funny stuff — but a lot of it was swing. He had quite a few stocks from the 30s and 40s basically, because he had his own dance band at one time so he had ordered all the stock arrangements. So you know we had “In the Mood” and “String of Pearls” and The Casa Loma Orchestra stuff, and you know he had bunches of books of jazz transcriptions, Frankie Trumbauer solo books, and Chu Berry solo books, and Toots Mondello books you know, so we had all of these transcribed solos that he would give us to read.

MR: At some point did your father say, especially to you and John on trumpet, that, okay now it’s time to play music that’s not on the page, and how did he describe that?

PL: I’ll tell you, my first experience with that, because we never did that. What happened was we always read the solos that were written in there. They were little note solos that were written. And the first time I remember we were playing a talent contest in Dansville, New York with the family band, I’ve even got a picture of the night somewhere where somebody took it from the audience. And I had to stand up and read the transcribed solo. And I looked down and I lost my place so I just started improvising. And after the set I remember we finished and I went offstage to my two brothers and I said, “Man, I just made up my own stuff and it felt really great.” I was really enthused about it. And that was the first time I ever had really improvised on my own. And then from then on, it didn’t last that long, the spark, I mean we kept doing it as kids. And it didn’t really kind of hit me until I got into high school that that’s the direction I wanted to go in. And it wasn’t my father, it was my school music teacher that really started the spark about jazz.

MR: I see. Were you and your brothers, did you have some notoriety in high school like almost as if you were the quarterback and the wide receiver and the fullback or something on the football team?

PL: No I mean we had some articles in the paper. We auditioned for the Ted Mack Amateur Hour, we auditioned for the Mickey Mouse Club, I remember that. And they put little articles on us in the paper, but it wasn’t really something that went anywhere or followed us anywhere. You know everybody knew that we played music and we were, they knew

MR: Where did you go to audition for the Mickey Mouse Club?

PL: It was in Rochester, Sibley's I think, it was at Sibley's, that building upstairs on one of the floors. Jimmie Dodd came and he was one of the guys that auditioned us. And Steve Gadd of course went, I think Steve won, I think Steve won an audition. I remember Steve Gadd auditioned.

MR: Wow. Was there any rivalry with your brothers regarding music?

PL: No. We've always gotten along. We never had any kind of arguments that I can see. Basically I was the first one interested in jazz. I got interested in it, I roped my brother John and Joe into it, I got them into it, and then some local kids that were in school with us, I got one of them to play bass and a couple of them played trumpet. But we never really fought over anything. Even to this day we're still in kind of an agreement. And it's kind of unusual. You know I played a club here called The Rex and I know the club owner Bob is always amazed that the three brothers get along you know. But we've always gotten along.

MR: I'm happy to hear that.

PL: It was instilled, my father did that to us, just to make sure that none of us — I mean there was always little spats occasionally but never any grudges.

MR: I see. What were your aspirations? You went to SUNY Potsdam. I had a SUNY experience at Fredonia. And I wonder, when you went there was your jazz interest met at SUNY Potsdam?

PL: I have to say no, but I auditioned for Fredonia first. That's where I wanted to go because I knew that Don Menza and Sam Noto — or Don Menza had gone there. And there's a bass player named Linc Milliman who played bass — Linc was basically from six miles outside of Mount Morris is where he grew up, so I used to play with his father, his mother and his sisters and with Linc. And I knew they went to Fredonia so I auditioned for Fredonia but they turned me down because I couldn't sight sing. You know they made me, like I played, an audition, and then they put a piece of sight singing up there and I never sang anything and so they turned me down. And then I went to Potsdam. See the other thing was that I wasn't a clarinet player, I was a saxophone player and wanted to get into New York State as a saxophone player. But they didn't take saxophone players. But the year that I went, in '62, I was the first saxophone player in the State of New York that was allowed to go into the State of New York school system as just primarily a saxophone player. Because you always had to be a clarinet major and then double on saxophone player for what they had at that time called the "wind ensemble," you probably remember William Musser had the wind ensemble. So when I went to Potsdam my music — you know at the time he did not want me there. He actually said, "How did

did not want me, made it difficult for me. And then there was an opening in the wind ensemble and Joe Roccisano, I don't know if you know Joe, Joe was a great saxophone player. Joe was going to school at the time and he auditioned me on tenor to go into the wind ensemble, and he said, "Yeah, that's good. You'll pass. You can go in." And my clarinet teacher balked and said, "No I don't want him in the wind ensemble." So with that animosity I only lasted one semester. And you know jazz was not — you know the school system at that time, the big band had to rehearse off campus. You couldn't use the school facilities and all that. But yet they had sent a jazz combo from Potsdam to a Villanova festival and they got all kinds of notification, and a lot of these places got awards. I see Nick Brignola at Ithaca College with Reece Markowitz, they all got noticed and they won this award but yet you couldn't practice jazz in the practice rooms at Ithaca College. It was a different era back then. Now Potsdam has a great jazz program. All of the schools do. Eastman does — at one time Eastman, you know, forget it.

MR: Well if it'll make you feel any better regarding Fredonia, Don Menza told me when he was at Fredonia he said practicing bebop was a felony, practicing Dixieland was just a misdemeanor.

PL: Yeah I know Menza told stories about that. It was the turn of a different era of music. And I just happened to be right in the middle of that thing that was turning around in the 60s. And we're talking 1962. I'm sure about ten years later everything had changed around because every school had to have some kind of big band or jazz band program.

MR: Yeah I want to talk about that a bit later. I was reading in the *Grove Dictionary of Jazz* there's an entry on you and your brothers. And I was going to read — you know it's a challenge, they try to describe musicians' styles, sometimes in one sentence for space reasons. And I was going to read what they said about you but I'm thinking how would you like an opportunity to describe your own playing and in about twenty words. Can you do that?

PL: Well my playing comes from — the earliest references that I referenced were basically Gerry Mulligan, Prez, Stan Getz, Sonny Rollins, Coltrane. I mean I listened to all those guys. Lester Young was a huge influence on me and even to this day, I went through all the periods of music listening to everybody, studied with everybody that I could. And you know, playing with Elvin you had to play a certain way, or I felt that I did, or more modern, but even now today I go back to Lester Young and the things that I learned about Prez. So you know I'm drawn back to that. But I would say Stan Getz, Richie Kamuca, Lester Young for sure. I mean Prez, I copied a lot of Prez solos. And Gerry Mulligan was a huge influence on me, and all the guys that worked with Gerry Mulligan, because I bought all those albums, you know, "Ben Webster Meets Gerry Mulligan," Johnny

MR: Nice. Well I'll read what they said. They should have called you. In regards to your style, "His style is derived principally from that of John Coltrane to which he adds his own rhythmic looseness and lyricism.

PL: Yeah I mean you listen to early Trane and it's Prez and it's Gene Ammons and it's Dexter you know. I mean they're all in there. I mean everybody's kind of mixed up in there. But I mean the time that I was probably being more recognized for my soloing would have been with Elvin Jones. With Buddy of course I was known as a soloist but with a big band you're only going to get a small chunk of space to solo. Right? Maybe one big feature that you get that you know — the suite was something that I kind of inherited from Don Menza. And so with Elvin's band, when they heard me play, and those articles were probably written back then, I was heavily into those by Trane. It's pretty hard not to go down that road when you're playing with Elvin, and then especially when you're playing with Elvin and McCoy and Reggie Workman. All of the sudden there's that trio behind you and, you know, I'm going to come out and play like Zoot Sims it just didn't fit the flow of where I felt the time was. And I wanted to study and I learned that music. I used to go see Coltrane all the time when I was in Rochester or going to Berklee. That was one of the things you did. When he came to town you went down to see him.

MR: Can you describe what that was like? Leaving the club after seeing Coltrane?

PL: Well there was a couple of times when I left the club early and had to go outside just to kind of calm down because it was frantic, sometimes in that period we were catching him. '64, '65 '66. It was just surely an eye opener and I learned, you know, the dedication. You used to watch Trane come off the bandstand and then go right into a room — either a room where they put the beer cases and all that, and he'd just keep playing. And then I was lucky enough when I was at Berklee one of my friends was a waiter at the Jazz Workshop. And he got us to go in, in the daytime we'd go in and listen to Trane practice. Because he would come to the Jazz Workshop, go into the dressing room, and then the three guys we would sit there and order a Coca Cola at lunch and there was nobody in the club and he would be practicing in the background and we'd be trying to figure out what he's doing. And he's right next to the bathroom so every once in a while we'd pretend we had to go to the bathroom and look in, and I remember seeing that he had a whole tableful of reeds and we used to just listen to see what he would be practicing.

MR: I'm trying to form a question here about what did you try to copy?

PL: Oh boy, Trane, I mean the sound was one of the things that I've always been drawn to. His use of vibrato in the later period, you know where he was almost into a classical

but not playing in that style. And so what I was always listening to the way Trane would use his vibrato, where he would play — usually a jaw vibrato but sometimes a jaw and a diaphragm combination vibrato. I heard Sonny Rollins doing the same thing where they combine the flute — ha-ha-ha-ha-ha — with the ya-ya-ya-ya jaw, so you get two things working at once. You get the depth of the stomach vibrato — ha-ha-ha-ha — that's going here and there. It's kind of tricky. I just picked it up. But I mean I just copied a lot of his solos, not in total but like what was that phrase, and I would listen to what's that idea. I would pick little devices out to see if there were things that I liked.

MR: Did he ever go out too far, you know in his last year or so, for you to keep up with?

PL: There were times when, you know like one of my, let's see "Expression," that album, there's one there I really like from that period back and then forwards, the other ones like "Om" and some of those other ones — "Live in Seattle" there's some things that I like. But there was a point where I decided I'm going to listen to all of that stuff and see what he's trying to get across in there. You know I always studied it, being an educator also. I mean I always wanted to kind of understand what's going on with him. Some of it I didn't like all the time, but I always enjoyed the way he played. Not always the combination of instruments that he had, I could see he was searching for a certain thing. Everything didn't appeal to me. But most of it did.

MR: Okay. When you were at Berklee were you and your classmates sort of waiting for the phone call?

PL: I wasn't thinking that way when I first went there because when I came from Potsdam, well I didn't come right there I ended up working for a year and did a lot of day jobs to save money to go to — to get the tuition because at the time Berklee was expensive — $500 a semester. A thousand dollars a year in 1962, that was unheard of.

MR: It's still unheard of.

PL: My father had to go to some shady characters. I got enough, as much money as I could but my father tried to get a loan from the bank and they wouldn't give it to them so he had to go to some other guys that he knew that were kind of under the radar. But he got the loan to get me to go to my first semester at Berklee. And then my other two brothers followed. John went to Potsdam and then cam to Berklee. Joe went directly to Berklee afterwards.

MR: I see. They should have given him at least a discount for the family.

PL: Right. Third one's free.

MR: But you know I'm sort of wondering, it seemed like Berklee was a place where bandleaders could go and pick up young musicians who were hungry to get out there and play.

PL: Well you know in my first two years I didn't think that way. I was just basically trying to learn everything I possibly could. We had bands, small bands, and Saturday morning, Sunday morning we'd be rehearsing with our own big bands that we put together. We had access to the practice rooms so we could put groups together. And there were a lot of guys that were in school at that time who later became big names. But we were all just trying to learn. By my third year, you see my problem was I made the mistake of every year going back to Mount Morris, New York, which meant that there were no music jobs or an occasional gig here and there. I had to get a factory job, a truck driving job, a construction job. So I did that every year except for my last year. When I went my last year I said you know what? I'm going to stay in Boston and see what I can pick up. And I stayed in town and as soon as — like a week afterwards I got a call to do a summer in Old Orchard Beach, Maine. It was a quartet. Gene Roma, the drummer, a very fine drummer, was in the band. And I went up there and did that for about two months, or a month and a half, and then my brother Joe was working with Chuck Israels and Hod O'Brien down in Tanglewood. And he said, you know there's a jazz club here across the street up on the hill called Avalock, which they have a jazz club in there and Randy Weston is leaving and they're looking for — they put a — you ever see that movie "The Gig?" where they've got all these guys — well this was the gig. Exactly like it. They put all these guys together, young college guys had gotten this gig and they needed a saxophone player. So my brother Joe finagled it and I left the gig in Old Orchard Beach, came down to Tanglewood and took this gig and it was all of us living in a house. Now they didn't have a drummer so they ended up getting the guy who was the bass player, the real jazz guy in the movie, they ended up getting a drummer actually who was the real jazz guy. Gene Gammage was the drummer that worked with Oscar Peterson, Chet Baker, Zoot Sims, and Gene was looking for a gig. So he came up. And so here's all of these young college guys and this one guy who'd been on the road with everybody and lived with Scott LaFaro and lived with Joe Romano. So Gene, of course he's — I got to hang out with him and he became a real close friend all through the years. And then I went back to Berklee and that was my last year. I started the semester in September, about two weeks in — you want me to keep going with this story because this is where it goes.

MR: Yeah, yeah.

PL: Okay so I went back to Berklee. Jimmy Mosher was the alto player who had just gotten off the summer tour with Buddy Rich. He did the "Away We Go" Jackie Gleason special, but he came back to Berklee to teach. So they put me in his ensemble, and I was in for about two weeks. On the second week we all go to a bar afterwards on a Friday night

road — Lynn Biviano, the trumpet player. And he was out with Woody Herman. And so Jimmy Mosher was hanging out with Johnny in the bar and he said, "You know you've been in school too long." He said, "You should go out on the road." And we're all drinking. And he said, "There's a job opening with Buddy Rich. I'm going to make a call and get you the gig." This was while we're all drinking on Friday. So Monday morning comes around and I see Jimmy Mosher and I say, "Okay where's that gig with Buddy Rich?" He said, "Quit all your classes and leave for New York, you start Thursday." So I said oh my God. And I was in the recording band with Herb — I had to go tell Herb Pomeroy I was leaving school. I had to fly home and get a suitcase and I'd never flown before. I had to go back to Rochester. I had to fly to New York, and Ernie Watts, Ernie and I were already in an ensemble the year before with Charlie Mariano, but Ernie had taken the gig with Buddy Rich playing lead alto. And Charlie Owens, who was in Berklee also had taken the second alto gig. So when Jimmy Mosher got me the gig Ernie knew who I was, cause we had worked together. So I went to New York and I rehearsed for a week with the band without playing. We were working The Riverboat and I went down every night and caught the band so I could see what was going on. Last night Bobby Keller was the saxophone player, he came up to me and handed me the bag of suits, because there was a suit and a tuxedo. He says, "You got it." Sunday morning we flew to Minneapolis/St. Paul. The first night, Frank Sinatra. At first, I get off the bus and Jay Corre, who was the tenor player, missed the plane, so I had to play the lead book, which I had never seen. I had only been rehearsing the fourth book. Now I'm stuck playing "West Side Story" and then backing Sinatra. A test of fire.

MR: You can't make this up.

PL: No. The thing is, both of my gigs, when I went with Elvin it was the same thing. No preparation just like bang, just jump in there and had to do it.

MR: Well that's like graduate school, you know? You can only learn so much in school. What was Buddy like to play right in the beginning for? Was he like —

PL: You know he hardly, he just said hello to me at the airport, and you know I could see the show business aspect of it, because he would always, Buddy was Buddy. And I just kept my head low and just read the book, did the book. Jay Corre came back after a couple of nights and I went back to the fourth book. And we were just touring around. We did one month's tour down into the south. We went back to Los Angeles and played Marty's on the Hill I believe, and then we left for a tour of the Orient. We went to Taipei and Hong Kong and Japan, and all through, and then ended up in Hawaii. So we did a month tour into the whole month of December into January.

MR: Was your mother happy for you?

PL: I think they missed the fact that I wasn't there for Christmas the first year of '67 — I was Christmas in Japan. You know that was hard for an Italian family, not having everybody together. And then, they both were, my father was, I mean the first time he saw me on the "Ed Sullivan Show" he goes everything looks fine you know.

MR: That's great. Well moving from any big band, as you mentioned, you get a limited amount of time to solo. You know sometimes the leader might say open it up, go around again, but still not too long. So going to Elvin Jones, I'm guessing that was a big change in adjustment for you.

PL: Yeah we used to have a chart on Buddy's band called "Uptight." Do you remember that? [sings] Uptight. So Dave Liebman told me he says, "Man you went from uptight to up loose" you know. Because you know all of a sudden now I'm coming from, you know, you have a solo in a big band and you stand up, you've got to go, it's like machine gun time you know, most of the time, unless it's a ballad or a medium thing, but you have to kind of jump in there. And you don't leave space, none of that stuff really comes — now I go with Elvin, the only thing he ever told me, a couple of things was I played the Vanguard and he said, "Look, you're not playing long enough." Because we only played four tunes a set, maybe five. Four tunes a set. So he says, "And you've got to take your time and develop your solo." And that's something that I had learned earlier on from Lester Young. So it wasn't hard to go back to it, but you know don't forget I had almost done seven years with Buddy Rich of doing the other thing. Now I have to go back and learn a whole new way of playing. Because with Buddy I was always playing on top of the beat. Now Elvin's time was really — there was a lot of space in the bar that Elvin has, a lot of space. Joe Farrell told me, he said, "Once you play with Elvin," he said, "you'll have the — you'll realize what your time is and you'll have the best time that you could ever think about." Because he's not going to spoon feed you. It's not [claps] it's like a big wash of sound. And you had to kind of learn how to put — put your lines on top of it, not rush, be relaxed, take your time, leave space, leave space to draw the rhythm section into your solo, which again was something I had learned from Lester Young.

MR: Was the difference in bass players — make a difference in your playing when you were with Elvin?

PL: Yeah. Because the bass player a lot of times, you would rely on the bass player to kind of give you the steady four, where Elvin would kind of maybe — playing loosey goosey around it. Strong bass players — you know Elvin relied on a strong bass player. He didn't like a bass player that played the amp over the sound of the string — you know the percussiveness of the string. You know if he was putting this much intensity into the ride cymbal, and the bass player was just doing this because he's allowing it, there's a

that. He didn't have many of those guys. All the guys that I played with, from when I first went on, were all strong bass players.

MR: I don't know if you can answer this but if you were playing an extended solo with Elvin Jones' trio, what is going through your head? Are you thinking harmonically? That's my question.

PL: No I know all the changes. When I learn a tune I have to know everything that's going on that there needs to be. Do I hear it at first? Maybe not. When I first learned how to memorize in blocks, when I was working in the factories, that's how I learned my tunes. I used to work for Mohawk Tires and I worked for the canning factory in Mount Morris where I had to load pallets, stack pallets up with boxes six feet high and then ring the buzzer for the forklift, and the next stack. So I'd do this all day long. So I would bring my tune in, and I had a tune on an index card with the changes all written out. And I'd tack it up to the post that was right next to me, and as the boxes came down I'm going G minor seventh, C minor seventh. And by the time I got home at night I knew the changes like I learned poetry. Because I had a great English teacher who taught me how to memorize poems. And so I learned them. But I didn't hear them. Now I get home, I know all the changes and don't have to look at a book. I know the melody and now I start looking at the melody and seeing what I memorized, and then starting to play up and down what I had memorized to hear it that way. So it's kind of a weird way of learning how to play, but that's how I did it. So when I was with Elvin, the changes were not a problem. Then I realized that melody is really your prime source to glean improvisational ideas from. My biggest thing is, listen to somebody play "Straight No Chaser." Okay? You got that melody [scats] all that chromaticism. The minute the head stops, how many people reference the melody? They go right into their stock way of playing on the blues, but yet there's that great source there of all that chromatic material. Very few people glean — and that's a good way to practice. Think of that tune and then solo off that tune, and then go back to playing standard and think about well what does that melody mean?

MR: Good advice.

PL: I mean today, I mean a lot of it is technique. There's so much technique involved in playing today. You know Bobby Shew once told me a great — you know Bobby Shew — he told me a great statement that I've always remembered. He said, "Do you play to impress or do you play to inspire?" And so I always think about that when I play. I'm not trying to dazzle you with my technique. I'm trying to like draw you into a theme, a melody, a theme, a set of changes in a direction that I'm going with my solo. So building the solo is important you know. I think you have to depend on who just soloed before you, because you have to keep that in your mind. If you have somebody playing hundreds

to just be a continuation — and if you want people to listen to you basically you have to deflect the direction and go a different way to build your solo, to grab the listener.

MR: If you're teaching a student and they are, let's supposed they're playing on "So What." And they're obviously missing the half-step change. My question is about wrong notes. What term do you use with them with — I mean wrong notes now seems to be a thing like well don't call them wrong notes. So how do you approach them with — you're playing wrong notes. That's the best I can say.

PL: Yeah what I do is I actually make students play wrong notes. I'll do a tune like "So What" and I'll just say okay, let's figure out the notes that are going to sound bad on D minor seventh, okay? Let's figure the notes that are going to be something, and let's work on hitting that note. E flat. Right? Okay, and F sharp on the D minor seven chord. Let's practice hitting those notes, first of all to get rid of the fear of hitting a wrong note. Because that's one thing that keeps people from going, keeps them from searching, is they're always afraid like oops I'm going to — so I just say, "Okay let's play a blues." I play a blues and I say, "Just play as much activity that you want that is chromatic and out but resolve it toward the end, come back into the chord." So if you've got D minor seventh, play three bars out of chromatic nonsense no matter what you hear but get into the D minor back at the end. Now hold some of those notes that you find unpleasant and resolve them. See where they go, so that if you're ever into that spot where — but don't be afraid of them. Because those sometimes are the strengthening notes that pull you into the chord some — you know upper and lower — well I don't want to get too technical, but upper and lower — appoggiatura — upper and lower chord tones, half step above, half step below, pentatonics. I do that all the time with the students. If I have them playing on a D minor pentatonic I'll say, okay play the pentatonic a flat six away and a flat five — or you know a sharp five and a flat five away. So D minor right, with the B flat minor pentatonic, play a couple of notes of B flat minor, come into D minor. More notes of B flat minor, come back in. Do the same thing — it's the root and the fifth, right? Because in harmony the fifth can always be replaced by another note. The root has to be there but the fifth is one of the notes that you can kind of get rid of on a chord and still keep the quality, right? So this is a device to train you. So D minor seventh, you would play E flat minor pentatonic, right, or a C sharp minor into D, right? Or a half step above the fifth, B flat minor or A flat minor below the fifth. But you just play a few of those notes and then come back in. And then a few notes out and then come back. Just get used to hearing those notes out but feel the resolution. That's a little more advanced than learning how to play one or two wrong notes, but those are devices that you can use because if you hear anybody play "So What" nobody plays in the mode at all. Maybe

went out, in and out of the chord, up or low, the neighbor tones, there's so many devices, with Trane it was superimposed "Giant Steps" changes over it before he would come back in. But there was so much theory there, but it all came from the fact that if you want to play the Dorian mode in a church setting the way those church modes, fine. You stay in the mode in a traditional way of speaking. But nobody ever plays that way when you're playing.

MR: That's very interesting because we make such a big deal out of modes. But I'm not sure that the people that are making a big deal about it are actually players. Sometimes they are critics trying to figure out how to describe —

PL: I mean what we learn as modes, I mean everybody's been playing those for centuries and improvising on them too you know. It gets a little bit hairier if you go on to more advanced thinking like Messian, you know Messian the composer, his modes of limited transposition take you in another direction, they're a whole different way of thinking about music. You know the altered scales and the diminished scales and all those things, the pentatonic scales and the Hungarian double harmonics and all of these scales — people use them in jazz but —

MR: Well you went from Woody Herman and Buddy Rich and Elvin Jones, were there any gigs that you turned down along the way?

PL: Well I was with Woody Herman only for a short bit, I just went out to help Frank Tiberi and they just called me up as a sub. I loved it, but I wasn't with them for a long time. Same with the Glenn Miller band. I went out for a bit to help somebody that needed to get off for a week. Yeah, I turned down Joe Henderson believe it or not, I'll tell you why, because I was studying with Joe Henderson in New York. I was on Buddy Rich's band. And you know Joe called me one day, I was in a hotel, the President Hotel in New York and he called me and he said, "I need somebody to go on, to play bass clarinet." He wanted me to play bass clarinet. I said, "Joe, I can't play bass clarinet." I think Pete Yellin was doing the gig maybe at the time. I'm not sure if Pete was doing it. But he wanted me to go out and play with the band and he had this idea of bass clarinet and I just said I can't do it. I'm not a bass clarinet player. I mean I had to play clarinet with Buddy's band and I started on that instrument, but no way was I going to go out and embarrass myself with Joe Henderson.

MR: He had a big band at the time?

PL: This was the small band. He had like I think it was either Julian Priester, or I think he had three horns in front. I know at one point he had alto, trombone and himself on tenor. I had seen that band at the Vanguard. I don't know what he was thinking at the time, but he was always composing. When I was with him he was writing for Blood, Sweat & Tears,

when I was studying with him he was kind of doing that Blood, Sweat & Tears band that never took off. They were just rehearsing all the time.

MR: I remember seeing that, like Joe Henderson is with Blood, Sweat & Tears? Because I loved Blood, Sweat & Tears.

PL: I went to take a lesson one time and Joe says, "Look at this," he said, "I got a complete brand new Magnavox sound system." He goes, "They gave me a tenor, a bari, an alto, a soprano." Because Magnavox owned Selmer at the time. He said, "I got all of this stuff they gave me because I joined a rock band. I played jazz all my life nobody ever gave me anything," he said, "I go with one rock band and look at all the stuff they give me."

MR: Going back to Buddy for a minute, of course it was mostly young guys but there was some older veterans in that band like Al Porcino.

PL: Yeah, Al came on just after I joined. He came on in January of '68.

MR: Were those guys, did they teach you anything?

PL: Yeah I mean Al Porcino and Art Pepper came on right at the same time, right? So I sat next to Art Pepper for almost a year on Buddy's band, and Menza came on around the same time too. See when Jay Corre left in Vegas in '68 I took the tenor chair for about a month and then Don Menza came on the lead chair and I went back to the fourth chair, which was good for me because I got a chance to kind of hang out with Art Pepper and hang out with Don, who taught me a lot. Menza taught me a lot. I mean he was like a father to me, he taught me all kinds of — still to this day we talk almost every week. And so yeah, I'd hang out with these guys, Art Pepper was great. Al was really interesting, and he had given me a whole bunch of Charlie Parker tapes. I used to drive him around. I had a Volkswagen that I rented and I would take him to places that he had to go. And he gave me a bunch of Charlie Parker reel to reel tapes that he had done when he was on Woody's band and he had played the Apollo Theater and he took his reel to reel tape recorder and held it up backstage next to the speaker back there, and he taped all of these Bird shows and then he gave them to me and I put them on cassette. I still have them downstairs. They're all out on CD now but, yeah Al would give me stuff. And of course a lot of stories about all those, the older guys.

MR: Yeah. I heard a story, something about the Playboy Club with Buddy Rich and Al?

PL: Yeah downstairs in Hugh Hefner's, he had a game room downstairs in the bar with a big glass window that went into the swimming pool. And Al Porcino swam by with nothing on, in the nude, by the window of the pool. Yeah.

MR: Did your, your entrance into jazz education and academia, was that partly to change a lifestyle of being on the road?

PL: I never thought I'd be — my father was a music teacher. I helped my music teacher in the

Teacher's College and never thought about teaching. Went to Berklee, it never crossed my mind. I moved to Canada in '74 and I was with Yamaha at the time. I had signed with Yamaha in the States, the last couple of months with Buddy Rich and so when I came to Canada I was with Yamaha. And they called me and they said we've got this young student who is, they called him the "rising star" the Yamaha Rising Star Award. And we wondered if you'd give him a couple of lessons. I said gee, I never taught anybody. I don't know about teaching. They said well give him a try. So I had him come by my house on Saturday mornings, and we'd go there for four hours, and I'd basically just retraced my steps of how I learned, what I did. Because I had lots of notes. I mean I had been, since being at Berklee I had all kinds of notes. I learned how to take notes. I learned how to write all my practice routines down. So I just — I listened to him play and I could see what he needed, if it was musculature, embouchure, whatever, I could see that. And then the theory about improvisation was something I had just picked up on my own through a Berklee correspondence course when I was in Potsdam I was studying the Berklee correspondence course. And all the stuff I had learned at Berklee and then with Herb Pomeroy and Ray Santisi, Charlie Mariano, basically I just retraced my steps and showed him what to do. And then there was a college here in Toronto called Humber. Humber College is the Berklee of Canada. They had the first program. Matter of fact some of the guys from Berklee came up to help them establish this school. And there was an arranger named Ron Collier, one of Canada's most famous arrangers, one of the only guys that ever arranged for Duke Ellington and write for Duke Ellington in Canada. He started this program at Humber and they had been running about three or four years and they heard that I had taught this kid, who went eventually to this school. And they called me and asked me, they said, "Would you like to teach three more students?" I said, okay, private lessons and I wasn't getting a lot of work. See when I first moved to Canada I couldn't work for six months because of the union rules. You know they had a rule you couldn't work a steady job. I was sneaking across the borders, before computers and they could check up on you, I would go back to Rochester to work Italian weddings. I'd work up north so they couldn't trace me. You had to kind of do everything under the table. Because you weren't allowed to work a steady gig. I had a baby on the way and so I couldn't do it. So I took this job, and then Elvin called me in '75, like a year later I got the call and he had been trying to get me because he because he wanted me to join, he sat in once in Buddy's band in Ronnie Scott's a year before. He came in and sat in and took my number to see if I was interested. But then I moved to Canada and he lost all my contact information. So he called me. And that was around 1975. So taking this part time job teaching and then Elvin called me. So I took the job with Jones and I did the part time

I said, you know I'm going to be, I've got to travel to make a living here because I'm not doing anything in town. And so that's what happened. I got the job with Elvin and then I started to get more and more students each year but it was always part time until the 80s when they offered me a — in '87 they offered me a full time position. So I was off and on with Elvin for almost twenty years plus. I would go out with him — '75, '76, '77, '78, '79 — I was with him pretty much. Then I left for a bit, came back, left, came back, helped him out. And then his last two years I went back for his 75th birthday tour and did two years on a sabbatical that I had taken from the school, and then he passed away in the following year.

MR: Am I correct that you worked with him more in Europe than you did in the states?

PL: Yeah. We did mostly Europe. We did a lot of European festivals: Italy, the first tour I did was Sweden, Italy. We played Ronnie Scott's every year. The same as Buddy's band. Buddy would play Ronnie Scott's. Elvin would play Ronnie Scott's. We worked all through Europe. We did South America, we did a tour down there in 197 — I can't remember. In the 70s. This was when, we went down for the CIA it was like a branch of the CIA called the US Information Service. They sent us to every trouble spot in South America, right? So we went to Uruguay, Paraguay, Chile, Medellin, Bogota, Guayaquil, Santiago. You know, every place where there was some — they sent us down as kind of a peace thing. So we went there with that. We went to Japan with Elvin. In the states we always had a circuit. We would work the Vanguard two or three times a year. We worked a jazz showcase in Chicago. I don't remember — we worked a couple of other places in Detroit, Baker's Keyboard Lounge. There were some other spotty places that we would work but that's about it. There were only a few places. I don't remember — California we'd work the Jazz Bakery. But there wasn't a lot of activity going on at that time.

MR: Through your career have there been times where there was any racial subject coming into play? Black and white musicians etcetera?

PL: Yeah. That's just understand — that goes on. At that time when that used to go on on Buddy's band, not so much the members of the band but we would play Florida and Ernie Watts and Charlie Owens could not swim in the swimming pool, and this was, we're talking about '69, 70 you know. Elvin's band was not so much amongst the band members, it was more or less sometimes people who assumed certain things in Europe, that the band was all black and then I show up. At certain times I was the only white guy on the band. But never amongst the players. Occasionally there was a few guys that came on with some attitudes. Listen, you know, what are you going to do? I mean I grew up in a town that had that when I was a kid. It's as silly as we're looking at is the lowest ebb at one point in the town that I grew up in, so it was a whole different thing. I mean I never

Elvin. Elvin didn't see color. He was not — no never. We got off a train one time in Germany and the guy that booked us was this whole German Luftwaffe pilot who basically met us at the train. It was me, David Williams, who was from Trinidad; and Elvin; and Ryo Kawasaki was from Japan. And he comes up with a German accent and he says, "Well I thought you was an all-colored band?" He tells Elvin. And Elvin goes, "Well, we're all colors," he said.

MR: That's a good one. Well music is just like every other part of society you know, it's everywhere.

PL: It's stupid.

MR: Yeah. So you did some work with the Jamey Aebersold camps, so I want to know, like Jamey says, can anyone improvise?

PL: Well I think they can. I was talking about that — I watched a beautiful documentary this morning called "Moonlight Sonata" and it was all about a deaf child who got cochlear implants when he was young, and he got to hear, and he ended up performing. And it was a beautiful documentary. And I was telling my wife, I said, you know I used to do that with my classical players, and I said Jamey used to do that too. Even though you're working on a certain performance piece in a lesson, you should always let the student at some point in the lesson make up something of their own so they get the feeling of creating something. Even if it sounds horrible. And that's why Jamey puts on those one-chord Dorian vamps and just says, "play something." You know just play a couple of notes, what do you hear? He just tries to get them to come out of that just reading situation. I taught for Jamey for many years and then I moved on to the Skidmore Institute you know, in Albany, New York, in Saratoga. At Skidmore College they have a summer institute there. I worked there with Milt Hinton and Eddie Shaughnessy and so many guys. But I just ended up being a teacher, which is something I never thought I'd go into.

MR: Nice. Do your brothers, do you get on the phone with your brothers and trade band stories or when you — the rare moments you're all together?

PL: We're all together usually every Sunday around 1:30 and we talk on Zoom. And then we'll pass on stuff. Or I'll try to remember — I'll say do you remember this, or do you remember this happening or that happening. And we'll pass on information. We're always talking you know, or texting. No we're constantly in touch with each other. And Joe is not retired yet. John and I are both retired. Joe will be retiring this year. So I mean I retired not last year but the year before last, right? 2019, right? I can't remember now. And I had the whole year blocked off. I worked in Japan, had a couple of recordings, and a couple of weeks teaching here at some summer jazz clinics. I had concerts booked. And

so now I'm just practicing every day with the hopes that it's still going to happen. I think I've got a few more years left, how about some months?

MR: Well I have an inside source who, I don't know if you want to pursue this story or not, but something that happened with Tony Bennett and Al Hibbler?

PL: I know the story but I wasn't there, I only heard it third or fourth-hand so I don't want to repeat that. Would you mind if we didn't do that?

MR: I do not mind.

PL: I think you should talk to — who was on that gig — it would be Paul Langosch I think. If you know Paul Langosch I would contact him. I think it was Paul. I don't want to go there. Especially today.

MR: Yeah, you know jazz myths get spread around too much so —

PL: Yeah I've heard that story. Sorry audience.

MR: But along those lines I'll try a question that hardly ever works also, and that is, have you ever, do you recall just a terrible gig or series of gigs that you just couldn't believe you were involved in?

PL: Well there's, sure. I remember one night I had booked a gig with a group in town, a guy in town here who I'd worked for doing a lot of trade shows. And he said, "You have to go get fitted for a costume." So I went down to this place where they have theatrical costumes and I went and got fitted for the costume. And he said, "We're doing this dentists' convention and the theme is the movie "Tom Jones" so you have to get fitted for the satin pantaloons, the button thing, the George Washington wig, and he said, "I'll be playing harpsichord and we'll be playing tunes like "In a Twentieth Century Drawing Room.'" And I was taking anything at that time. This was in the early 70s. Now I had a week at the Village Vanguard. We finished on a Sunday night. The gig was on a Monday. So I finished Jones up on Sunday night, and Monday I go down to this gig at one of the hotels here, and I get on stage and there's the guys with the harpsichords, they're all having the George Washington wigs and the guys at the harpsichords was a bass player and a drummer. And we are in straw this thick with goats and chickens and all kinds of livestock with us, and we're playing, I was playing flute and saxophone. And we're supposed to be in a barnyard scene. And I thought to myself Jones one night and here the next night.

MR: That's real life right that.

PL: But you know what? Working with my father as a kid, learning how to work firemen's picnics and clam bakes and weddings and all of these jobs where you just took them because it was work, I just learned how to tough it out and tough it through. I mean there were times when I played with Elvin that I hated the gig because of certain things going

that it was always going to get better, there was always going to be bad nights and it's just one of those things. There's always good nights coming down the road at some point, you hope.

MR: Gee. Well that's something that students should know about, although those kinds of gigs are hardly around anymore. I think it's a shame.

PL: I've been on bands where I didn't like all of the players I was playing with. There was one band that I hated everybody in the band except the band boy. I liked the leader. But everybody else I couldn't stand working with but you had to do it. Once you got on the bandstand you had to function if you want to play. If you don't want to play the music you walked out. I've only walked off a couple of gigs and it's just because the leaders were so obnoxious — and after working with Buddy that's one thing I learned about working with Buddy Rich. After you work with Buddy Rich you never took any crap from anybody because you've seen the original act. I would watch these guys and they'd say, "I'm out of here, I don't need this." You know. And I walked off jazz gigs when very famous guys who I said I saw the original. I don't need to see a carbon copy, I'm gone. I don't need the money. At that point I didn't.

MR: I just watched a video with you and Buddy, and the set-up was very interesting because he looked like he would always look to his left when he played, for the most part.

PL: He always looked to his left, you know why that was, right?

MR: I do not.

PL: Oh okay, I asked him one time, I said — because I saw him one night and we were playing and he sat in with Basie's band and he knew all the charts — "Whirly Bird" he knew everything. And he came out, I said, "Buddy, how did you do that without" — because he doesn't read music. He said, "Well I know all the charts of every book," he said, "Tommy Dorsey," he said, "I have them all in my head." I said, "What happens if somebody throws you a chart you don't know?" He said, "You see why I'm always looking to the left?" He goes, "I'm always looking, I'm watching the lead trumpet player and the lead trombone player breathe. I don't care about the saxophone players, but I'm watching how they breathe. If I know they're going to go [takes a deep breath] I know there's something coming up and I can usually psych out the fill." That's what he told me. He said, "I learned that from working with Dorsey" he said, "I watched him breathe and I watched the lead guys breathe if there was something I didn't know." But he was fast. He picked up stuff so fast you know. I was always amazed how he did it. "Channel One Suite" when we did that we brought it into Las Vegas. We were playing there right after that Japanese tour. And my brother Joe was playing Buddy's drums because he was backing the singer who we were backing, Frankie Randall. So he had Joe come by in the

One Suite" goes [counts quickly], so it had that kind of, you know that fake three and five, which is really eight. But you know that's the way it was broken up. He listened to it for just a little bit and then he went, "Get off the drums" and he went up and played the part.

MR: Yeah, we wore out that record with Don's thing on that.

PL: Yeah. Menza on that.

MR: Well in that video I thought he was staring at you because for some reason you were set up right in his line of sight and I wondered what that was like. Because you were soloing.

PL: Well a lot of times you would rely on me for certain things. If I'm soloing he could tell when I'm going to finish. And also if you look at anytime you see if you can see my wrist, this wrist here, I always had a wrist watch that had the head of the watch turned backwards so that Buddy — Buddy would come off and he would say to me, "How long have we been up here?" And I would always just look like this. Because if I looked like this it would look like we were checking the time. So I just looked at my wrist and I could tell, okay 40 minutes. So he would always ask me that. And then, you know but at one point he was relying on me in hiring guys and Rick Stepman was hiring guys at a certain point. But he — you never saw him really look over at the rhythm section that much. He was always looking that way and down. I think it was an easy place for him to kind of put his head.

MR: Did he prefer the electric bass?

PL: Well you know I think when Joel DeBartolo and Ron Paley came on that when Paul Congelo we went to the electric bass. We had a lot of problems with bass players. There were times there when I was hiring and firing so many guys, and some really good guys, but you just couldn't get the right guy. We got Joel DeBartolo finally, we got Joel on there for a long length of time. But there were just times when you couldn't get a bass player that Buddy could agree with. I always felt, I've felt that Buddy always wanted sometimes a bass player who would kind of go with him if he wanted to move the music up just a little bit in tempo, and not hold him back. You know if you get a bass player that says no, this is where the time is I'm going to stay here. I don't think he always liked that, because sometimes he'd like to push the chart just a tiny step.

MR: Did you ever let a guy go that Buddy disagreed with? Like why did you let him go?

PL: I let guys go — I had to fire guys who basically, yeah guys he disagreed with also, but also there were guys that weren't up to the level yet and had to go. I mean I'm not going to name names but there were guys that we had to do that. It was just part of the thing. And once he got somebody that he liked, Joel DeBartolo was really I think one of the ones that stayed for quite a bit and that was a kind of a story, I don't know how much

Rochester, with Gap Mangione's band, and he had worked with Chuck Mangione and my brother Joe. And so I knew that he could play the gig. I hired him on the gig, he comes, and we were playing in St. Louis, Missouri in a big hotel, and Joel had never seen the book. Now Joel was kind of nervous, he was very nervous, and Joel had a stutter. He really had a problem stuttering. He ended up playing in the Tonight Show band with Johnny Carson for years. You know he was the bass player. So I got Joel on and Joel came on the bandstand and Buddy used to do this bit where he'd come out, and Dave Lama was the piano player and I think that was the time Dave was on, and Buddy would say, "Give me an A" and he'd yell down to the piano player. And the piano player would play an A and then Buddy would hit the snare drum and pretend he was tuning. Buddy comes on that night and he sees Joel back there and Joel is just shaking, and Buddy knows it's like a deer in the headlights. So Buddy — and I'm just going oh god, I'm just saying oh please. And so Buddy turns, instead of going to him he turns around to Joel and he goes, "Give me an A." And Joel went, "Aaaayyy" like that. Buddy fell on the floor, right off the stool, on the floor and was rolling around. He couldn't play for twenty minutes. I mean he just could not stop laughing, Buddy. And Joel was in. Buddy just could not — and that was kind of an old bit that they used to do up in Rochester, all the Italians.

MR: I see.

PL: "Give me an A." And you would just kind of trigger them.

MR: Nice move.

PL: That's a classic story. I was so relieved after that, because Buddy loved him after that.

MR: Well we've been at this for almost an hour, and I appreciate your stories and your career. I wanted to just go off music before we end. I'm wondering what the feeling in Canada has been about America in the last number of years.

PL: I'm just so disappointed. I'm kind of hopeful that this new party, the Democratic party will come in and kind of do something. I'm hoping they're getting blocked. I'm wishing today that both of those senators become democrats because there could be a whole new change for the country. I mean I've always voted Democratic. There's a couple of times when I maybe thought differently, but most of my ways have been Democratic. But I mean what these guys are pulling now is just really upsetting. I just can't understand it. And you know I mean I don't understand, first of all, living in Canada, right, I've lived in Canada now since 1974. Born in America. So I remember when I was a kid the word "socialism" was just like oh my God, it's like you're going to be you know like socialist, like communists. Socialism is communism. And yet they have social security, and every time a big corporation like the auto industry or anything goes bust socialism kicks in. So

when I first moved here I was really upset about the fact that my taxes all of a sudden, whoa, why am I paying this amount of taxes. I never had to pay a doctor's bill, two kids born, I mean the medical thing. And you feel so comfortable. There's that pressure of having the fact that when I was traveling with Buddy every month I had to pay $500 to Blue Cross. If I didn't get that in — my mother would say make sure your Blue Cross is — you know because if you ever get — you know that fear that you're going to lose everything if you have to go into the hospital. It's just not here. And so that's a big strain off. Now also the other thing is during this period here with Covid, the young musicians who have made $5000 last year, the government gives you $2000 a month subsidy to exist. So every young musician gets $2000. Or anybody that's out of work who can prove that they made $5000 in the previous year, they're giving $2000 a month so you can live on. Now it's just gone down to $1800 because they started taking taxes on it. So young kids who work part time jobs and were earning that kind of money, they get the subsidy basically, from the government. It's a social system, we may end up paying for it. But just having that — I guess you can't call it free medical because it's medical that you pay for, but just having that off your back is a big big weight off your shoulders. And you have this feeling of comfort. I mean I just dislocated my shoulder two weeks ago so I'm working with this shoulder. I had a slip and fall out on a walk. I went out and it was just so painful. I went down and I went right into the hospital emergency. They put me out, they pulled it back, right in. Within three hours I was back home with the shoulder in and they started me on physio. I have another month of physio to go but I wish the U.S. could realize that so what, you pay a little bit more in taxes — people that can't afford it they'll end up with it. Guys that can afford it then so what, and then everybody's covered. I'm telling you, I think that would make a lot of things better down there. I feel, I don't know, you know you have a teaching job you get it. But if you work with certain companies you have a medical plan. But if you get fired or laid off it's gone, a lot of it.

MR: All right. I appreciate the observation. Do you have any personal feelings about why this pandemic has occurred? Why it occurred in 2019?

PL: I don't. I mean I just know that this is something that's been coming. My outlook on this right now is I'm trying not to be negative. I try to use this time for myself to grow. I'm exercising, I'm practicing every day, exercising, trying to get out. Luckily now I have a house with a backyard and different rooms and different levels that I can go to. If I had an apartment I may be thinking differently. But you can still use it as a period for growth. I've always been — that was my thought all the time. I'm always thinking ahead and planning for the next thing to come and being ready for it. So I think you can use this time to kind of be ready for what's to come. I don't know why, I just know that when I

at night and she'd have to take her clothes off on the porch and hang them outside, and come in and take a shower. She worked with tuberculosis patients. So from a young kid all the way on, we were dealing with this all the time, with this, you don't want to catch this. Then all of a sudden polio kicks in and we had to deal with polio. So you probably were around at that time.

MR: Yes.

PL: So we all know — I remember my mother had to wear the masks all the time on the wards.

MR: All right. Well Pat this has really been great. And I'm glad we connected.

PL: Yeah, Monk, thank you very much. I hope this helps you and if you need anything else from me — now I'll try to get these done today, I'll see if I can remember how to fill out a W-2 or whatever they call it.

MR: Okay. I'm going to pause our recording and then we can sort of say adios.

PL: Sure.